

THE CHAOS STAR MANIFESTO

Egoism and the Marxist Critique of Capital — A Statement of Chaos Star Syndicalism

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Note on the Name

A name is addressed here: the position goes by Chaos Star Syndicalism. The two halves are not decorative. Syndicalism names the organizational content of sections V through VIII: the union of egoists, and the plain claim that leverage against capital is produced collectively or not at all. Chaos names the rest of the document — the refusal of moral law argued in section I and the refusal of the state’s claim to legitimate authority argued in section VII. Chaos in this sense is not disorder sought for its own sake, which nothing here has recommended; it is the condition that remains once the fixed ideas that were said to hold a moral and a political order in place have been named as fixed ideas, in the manner of proposition 5, and set down. The star is the figure elsewhere given to exactly that condition: a point with no privileged direction and no center asserting one, which is the geometry an amoralist anti-statism is left holding once the compass it was handed has been discarded.

The name is not exempted from the test the document applies to everything else it names. Proposition 49 warns that a union which makes demands in its own name has become a spook; the same test is run here on the name of the tendency the union belongs to. Chaos Star Syndicalism is used because it currently does the work of letting people who hold this position find one another, not because the name has earned a standing independent of that work. Should it stop doing that work, proposition 5 already gives the instruction, and it is followed here as everywhere else: drop it.

Preamble

What follows is a statement of position, not an argument for conversion. It rests on a set of commitments held together as a single structure: an error theory of moral discourse; ownness as the relation between a person and their own body and attributes; amoralism as practice; the Marxist critique of capital as structural analysis; and anarcho-syndicalism understood as organized self-interest rather than as a moral vocation.

These commitments are usually held apart, and often by people who regard the others as incoherent. Stirner’s readers have generally treated class organization as one more abstraction to be dissolved.¹ Marx, for his part, devoted several hundred pages of *The German Ideology* to ridiculing Stirner under the name “Saint Max.”² The position set out here does not paper over that quarrel. It claims that each commitment, taken on its own terms, survives contact with the others — and that the conflict dissolves once moral vocabulary is removed from the argument and replaced with the language of interest, dependency, and leverage.

Two features of the method should be stated in advance. First, no proposition here is defended on the ground that believing it would produce good consequences. That form of argument is unavailable once section I is accepted, and it is in any case the standard route by which useful fictions are readmitted. Second, where the position diverges from a source it draws on, the divergence is marked rather than smoothed over. A synthesis that works only because its components have been quietly softened is not a synthesis.

The propositions are numbered continuously for ease of reference, not because they form a deductive chain; several sections could be read in a different order without loss. Commentary follows each group in smaller type, and carries the citations.

I. On Morality

Error theory; spooks; the amoralist practice

1. There are no moral facts. Moral claims purport to describe objective, categorically binding features of the world; no such features exist; therefore all positive moral claims are uniformly false.
2. This is a claim about the world, not about language. Moral utterances are genuinely assertoric — they mean what they appear to mean, and are simply mistaken. The error is systematic and deeply embedded, which explains why exposing it changes little in ordinary discourse.
3. The position is therefore distinct from non-cognitivism, which holds that moral utterances are expressions of attitude rather than assertions and so cannot be false. Non-cognitivism is too charitable. People making moral claims do mean to be describing how things stand, and the honest verdict is that they are wrong rather than that they were never trying.
4. What presents itself as moral obligation is, on inspection, the demand of some party wearing the costume of universal authority: God, Humanity, the Nation, the Revolution, Justice, the Greater Good, Rights. These are fixed ideas — spooks — which acquire power over individuals in proportion to those individuals' belief that they stand above them.
5. A fixed idea is identified by a simple test, and the test is practical rather than theoretical: does the thing continue to make demands after it has stopped being useful to the one it makes them of? Anything that answers yes is being served rather than used.
6. Moral discourse performs a function despite being false, and the function is obedience. A person who believes their subjection is merely imposed continues to look for the exit; a person who believes it is righteous will guard the door themselves, unpaid.
7. The historical record supports this without needing to be forced. The moral vocabularies of any given period correspond with unembarrassing closeness to the requirements of its dominant arrangements, and are revised when those requirements change.
8. The rejection of moral law does not abolish reasons for action. Reasons remain, grounded in what the acting individual actually wants and in the situation they actually occupy, rather than in a law claiming jurisdiction from outside.
9. Preferences are not arbitrary merely because they are not objective. They are the products of a particular history, body, and situation, and they are as stable and as motivating as anything in a person's life. The demand that a preference be cosmically underwritten before it may be acted on is a demand nobody has ever actually met.
10. This position is amoralist, not misanthropic. It does not license cruelty; it observes that cruelty rarely serves the one who practises it, that most people want very little of it, and that these observations were always doing the work the moral prohibition took credit for.
11. Amoralism is likewise not nihilism in the sense of holding that nothing matters. It holds that what matters, matters to someone, and requires no further licence than that.
12. The practical consequence is not lawlessness but the removal of a layer of pretence. Disputes that were conducted as disagreements about what is Right become disputes about what the parties want and what each can do, which is what they were in any case.

The technical statement is Mackie's. His opening claim is that there are no objective values; ordinary moral judgement carries a built-in claim to objectivity, and since that claim is false the judgements incorporating it are false too — hence “error theory.” He supports it chiefly with two arguments. The argument from relativity takes the actual variation in moral codes across societies as better explained by their differing ways of life than by differential perception of a common objective truth. The argument from queerness observes that objective values would have to be entities or qualities of a very strange sort, utterly different from anything else in the universe, and would require a correspondingly strange faculty of moral perception to detect them.³ Mackie himself did not draw amoralist conclusions; the later chapters of the same book set out to invent morality, treating it as a useful human institution to be constructed knowingly rather than discovered.⁴ Stirner arrives at the same destination without the analytic apparatus and a century and a half earlier. The sacred, whatever its content, is for him whatever has been elevated above the individual and then obeyed; the task is not to replace one sacred thing with a better one but to consume it.⁵ His target is expressly the humanist inheritors of Christianity: Feuerbach had relocated the divine predicates into Man, and Stirner's objection is that this leaves the structure of religion entirely intact while changing the name of the thing one kneels to.⁶ Both moves are required here. Mackie establishes that the claim is false; Stirner explains why it persists anyway, and why the exposure of one sacred object is so regularly followed by the elevation of another.

II. On the Body and Its Spooks

Ownness against freedom; gender, race, and the attributes one holds as property

13. The body is not a vessel containing a self. It is the part through which every other part acts. It is not owed to a god who made it, a state that counts it, a family that produced it, a doctor who classifies it, or a public that has opinions about it.
14. The relevant relation is ownness (*Eigenheit*), not freedom. Freedom is negative and granted: it is the removal of a constraint by someone in a position to remove it, and what is granted can be withdrawn. Ownness is the standing fact of the thing being mine, which requires no permission and survives its refusal.
15. To wait for permission to be what one is — from the law, from medicine, from a community, from a movement, from an ideology — is to have conceded ownership in advance and to be negotiating for its return on the other party's terms.
16. This is not a claim that permission is never worth seeking. It is a claim about what seeking it means. One may apply to an institution for a document, a procedure, or a resource as a matter of tactics, while conceding nothing about who the thing belonged to beforehand.
17. Gender, race, nationality, caste, diagnosis, and every comparable category are spooks in the precise technical sense established in proposition 8: fixed ideas, socially maintained, which present themselves as facts about a person's nature and then issue instructions on the strength of it.
18. Calling them spooks is not calling them unreal. They are enormously real in their effects: they allocate wages, housing, medical care, police attention, violence, and death with great consistency and considerable statistical regularity. What is denied is not their operation but their authority — the claim that they describe an essence which obliges the person described.
19. The distinction between a real effect and a real essence is the whole of the argument here. A border is not a fact of geology and it still stops a body. A category can be socially constructed from top to bottom and remain the most consequential thing about a person's week.
20. If there is no substantial self, there is no true gender or real race underneath the social one, waiting to be uncovered by sufficiently careful introspection. The essentialist and the reformer who merely reassigns the essence are making the same mistake from opposite ends.
21. What follows is not that these attributes must be discarded, which is neither possible nor desirable, but that they are held as property rather than as identity. They may be worn, used, refused, altered, inhabited, played with, or set down, in whole or in part, and the decision answers to the one holding them and to nobody else.
22. Ownership of an attribute includes ownership of its presentation: name, pronoun, dress, body, modification, voice, and the entire apparatus of how one appears. These are taken, not requested. A name one has asked permission for is a name someone else is holding.
23. The category one was assigned is not thereby made illegitimate to keep. A person who retains the gender, name, or affiliation they were handed, having examined it and found it serviceable, holds it on exactly the same terms as one who discards it: as property, not as fate.
24. Nor is any obligation generated toward others who share a category. A shared assignment is

not a shared essence and does not constitute a union in the sense of section V. Where obligation appears it is because a dependency is present, and the dependency will bear examination on its own.

25. Ownness does not abolish the material consequences these categories carry. Where a category is used as an instrument of subjection, it is opposed on the same grounds as any other imposed authority: as an attack on one's own position, not as an offence against justice, which does not exist.
26. This has a direct organizational consequence, developed in section V. A workforce sorted by race, gender, citizenship, or documentation is a workforce with a seam in it, and the seam is where capital applies pressure. Opposing that sorting is not charity extended to others; it is the removal of a handle by which one's own position is broken.

Stirner's distinction between freedom and ownness is the pivot of his second part. Freedom, he argues, is merely being rid of something, remains in the keeping of whoever granted it, and can therefore always be revoked; ownness is the individual's whole existence as their own, from which nothing is subtracted by permission because none was given.⁷ His treatment of the body and its powers as property belongs to the same discussion, where what one has is a matter of what one can hold rather than what one is licensed to hold.⁸ The application to race and gender is not Stirner's and is made here. It converges with an independent line of argument. Appiah's critique holds that races in the biological sense do not exist — the term has no referent answering to the essentialist picture — while racial identities do a great deal of real social work, so that the category must be assessed by its effects rather than by a referent it lacks.⁹

III. On Property and Possession

What is held against what is titled

27. Property in the legal sense is a relation between persons enforced by violence, described as a relation between a person and a thing. The description is the ideological part; the enforcement is the real one.
28. A title deed is not a fact about land. It is a standing instruction to armed men, and its efficacy depends entirely on their continued willingness to follow it.
29. Possession is distinct from property and is prior to it. What one possesses is what one holds, uses, and can defend; what one owns is what an authority certifies one may call on it to defend. The first requires no permission and the second is nothing but permission.
30. The egoist position on property is therefore not that property is theft, which presupposes a legitimate distribution from which the theft is a departure, nor that property is sacred, which is the same error with the sign reversed. It is that property is a fact about power dressed as a fact about entitlement.
31. This dissolves the apparent disagreement between the individualist who defends property and the communist who abolishes it, insofar as both are arguing about entitlement. The operative question is never who ought to have the thing, but who has it and on what basis it is held.
32. Applied to the means of production, the analysis yields the ordinary syndicalist conclusion by a non-standard route. The factory is not rightfully the workers'; rightful is a spook. It is held by its owner through a legal instrument backed by state force, and it is within the workers' capacity to hold it otherwise.
33. Occupancy and use is preferred to title as a standard, not because it is more just, but because it is the arrangement under which possession and entitlement coincide and the enforcement apparatus becomes redundant.
34. Personal possessions are not threatened by any of this and the frequent suggestion that they are is a debating tactic rather than an argument. A toothbrush is held and used by the person holding and using it. A factory held by someone who has never entered it is a different kind of object entirely, and the difference is not one of scale but of whether the holding requires an external apparatus to sustain it.

Proudhon's formula that property is theft is refused here in its own terms while its target is retained: the slogan presupposes a rightful distribution against which the theft is measured, which is precisely the kind of claim section I has removed.¹⁰ Stirner's treatment is the direct source for propositions 22 and 23: he holds that what he has in his power is his own, that he is entitled to as much as he is able to take, and that the appeal to rights in property disputes is an appeal to the very authority whose decision is in question.¹¹ The American individualist anarchists developed the occupancy-and-use standard of proposition 26 at length, generally accepting Stirnerite egoism while retaining a market in products.¹² The point at which this document parts from that tradition is the market: nothing in the egoist analysis of property recommends competitive exchange as the successor arrangement, and sections V and VI give the reasons for preferring the syndicate. Kropotkin's objection to the individualists is accepted on the empirical part — that production is already social and cannot

be disaggregated into individual contributions for the purpose of payment — while his ethical framework is not.¹³

IV. On Capital

The critique as structural description, not moral indictment

35. Capital is accumulated past labour set in command over present labour. Its authority is positional, not moral: it consists in ownership of the means through which the worker must act in order to live.
36. The wage contract is formally equal and materially asymmetric. The worker sells labour-power, the only commodity they reliably possess, and sells it because the alternative is destitution. The exchange can be perfectly fair by every standard internal to commodity exchange and still transfer value in one direction.
37. This is the analytically important point and the one most often lost. The critique does not allege cheating. It shows that no cheating is necessary, and that the result follows from the ordinary operation of exchange between parties who are formally equal and materially unequal.
38. Surplus value is the gap between the value the worker produces and the value returned as wages. It is not a deduction from a prior just wage; it is the reason the transaction is entered into by the purchasing party at all.
39. The worker's own past hours return as the instrument of their subordination. The plant was built by labour, is owned as capital, and confronts the next generation of workers as a condition they must accept in order to work at all.
40. The critique of capital requires no appeal to justice, to rights, to History, or to humanity's destiny. It requires only the observable relation between production and return, and the observable use made of that relation.
41. It follows that the critique survives the error theory intact. It was never a moral argument. Nothing in it is weakened by the claim that exploitation is not "wrong" in any objective sense; what it describes remains exactly the case, and the person it describes remains in exactly the same position.
42. Opposition to capital is therefore a matter of interest rather than conscience. Capital is opposed because it is a standing and concrete threat to the position of the one opposing it, and to everyone whose labour-power it draws on.
43. Competition among capitals compels individual capitalists to behave in ways no individual among them need have chosen. This is why the analysis is structural and why personal denunciation of employers is largely beside the point: replacing the holder of a position does not alter what the position requires.
44. Marx's analysis is accepted here as analysis and rejected as eschatology. The account of the commodity, of labour-power, of surplus value, and of the working day is retained. The philosophy of history, the necessary succession of stages, the guaranteed outcome, and the dictatorship of the proletariat are not.
45. The reason for the rejection is not opportunistic: a guaranteed outcome demands deference independent of whether it still serves the workers deferring to it, which is exactly the test proposition 5 gives for a fixed idea, and the historical record of that structure is available for

inspection.

The Stirnerite objection to Marx is not the economics. It is “Saint Max” in reverse: the suspicion that History, the Proletariat, and the eventual society have been installed as new absolutes in the position vacated by God, and that the vocabulary of necessity performs the same function as the vocabulary of providence. That suspicion is shared here and is what the next sections are built to avoid.

V. On the Union of Egoists

Solidarity reconstructed as dependency; the syndicate as instrument

46. Organization with other workers is not owed to class loyalty, shared essence, or the sacredness of solidarity. It is adopted because it works: leverage against concentrated capital is produced collectively or it is not produced at all.
47. The isolated refusal is negligible and the coordinated refusal is a threat. This is not an inspiring observation, merely a true one, and it is sufficient by itself to generate the entire syndicalist programme from self-interest without any moral premise whatever.
48. The appropriate form is the union of egoists: an association entered into for the sake of its members' own interests, sustained only while it serves them, and left without residual obligation when it does not. It is a relation one owns, not one that owns its participants.
49. This is distinguished from the fixed institution which, having been founded as an instrument, comes to be treated as an end and to make demands in its own name. A union that requires sacrifice for the sake of the union has become a spook, and is identified as one by the test in proposition 8.
50. The distinction is not academic. It is the practical difference between a fighting organization and a business union which manages its members' discontent as a service sold to the employer, and the second is what the first reliably becomes when it is permitted to become an end.
51. Because the individual's leverage is constituted by the association holding together, an injury to a fellow member is properly treated as an injury to oneself. This is not moral extension and not sentiment. The union's strength is the individual's strength; damage to it is damage to one's own position.
52. The old syndicalist formula — an injury to one is an injury to all — is therefore retained, but its foundation is replaced. It is not an ethical claim about shared humanity. It is a description of how leverage is actually constituted and actually lost.
53. The replacement is not a weakening. A person who holds the formula on egoist grounds will act on it in precisely the cases where it matters, whereas a person who holds it as a moral principle will act on it in the cases where acting is comfortable and discover sophisticated reasons in the others.
54. The scope of this identification is fixed by the actual structure of dependency and extends exactly as far as that structure runs. Where an employer can break one shop by supplying another, whipsaw locals against each other, relocate production, or draw replacement labour from an unorganized pool, the dependency is real and wide, and so is the injury.
55. Where no such link exists, no obligation is manufactured to imitate one. The boundary is drawn by causation, not by conscience, and there is no court above the individual before which the boundary must be justified.
56. In practice the dependency runs considerably further than it appears to at any given moment, because capital is mobile and labour markets are connected. Most cases in which solidarity appears to demand sacrifice are in fact cases in which the dependency is real but the time horizon is long and the causal chain is not visible from the shop floor.

57. The long horizon is not a concession to moral solidarity by another name. It is an ordinary feature of self-interested reasoning, and any egoism unable to accommodate delayed returns would also be unable to justify learning a trade.
58. Sympathy action, secondary support, and the organization of the unorganized are accordingly defended here on egoist grounds: not as generosity, but as maintenance of the conditions under which one's own refusal retains force.
59. The same reasoning covers every division by which a workforce is sorted and set against itself, whether by race, sex, citizenship, documentation, contract status, or trade. A seam is a place where pressure is applied. Closing it is self-defence conducted at the level where the attack actually occurs.
60. Reciprocity is the mechanism by which such an association is stabilized, and it requires no altruism to function. In a relationship expected to continue, the cost of defection is the loss of future cooperation, and that cost is borne by the defector.
61. It follows that the union's internal discipline is not a moral matter either. The sanctions applied to a member who crosses a line are not punishments in a desert sense; they are the price signals by which a cooperative arrangement remains one.

Stirner's association of egoists is set against both the state and the fixed society. The union is meant to be one's own instrument, entered for one's own sake and used up in the using; where it hardens into a society standing over its members, it has become another master and is to be treated as one.¹⁴ Landstreicher's translation renders the key terms differently throughout and restores some of the emphasis on dissolubility that the older English is accused of flattening.¹⁵ The syndicalist tradition supplies the content Stirner leaves abstract. Rocker's exposition presents anarcho-syndicalism as direct economic organization by the producers themselves, hostile to political parties and to the conquest of state power, with the union serving both as a weapon in the present struggle and as the framework of a later arrangement.¹⁶ The formula of proposition 44 is the standard labour slogan, given programmatic form in the IWW preamble's insistence that the working class and the employing class have nothing in common.¹⁷ The organizational model — unions as both instruments of struggle and the skeleton of a successor arrangement — comes from the French tradition and is stated in the Charter of Amiens, which asserts the union's independence from all political parties and sects while pursuing immediate improvements and eventual expropriation together.¹⁸ The theoretical support for propositions 51 and 52 is not anarchist in origin and is stronger for it. Axelrod's tournament work established that conditional reciprocity outperforms both unconditional cooperation and unconditional defection in iterated interaction, and that it does so without any assumption of benevolence among the players.¹⁹ Ostrom's field research established that groups facing common-pool resource problems regularly devise durable self-governing arrangements without either privatization or state enforcement, and identified the design features such arrangements share.²⁰ The move made in this section is to keep the syndicalist tactic and discard its ethical footing, replacing shared humanity with shared exposure. The result is narrower in principle and, in the overwhelming majority of real disputes, identical in practice. The name under which this position circulates, Chaos Star Syndicalism, is held on the same terms as the union it names: adopted because it is useful for finding one another, not because it has been elevated above the finding.

VI. On the Free Rider

The hardest objection, stated at full strength and answered

This section is set apart because the objection it addresses is the only one that threatens the structure rather than a detail of it, and because the usual replies are bad.

62. The objection: if each member acts only on self-interest, then the rational member takes the benefits the union wins and contributes nothing, since the contract covers them either way and their individual contribution is negligible to the outcome. Egoism therefore does not generate the union; it generates scabs.
63. The objection is not a debating point. It is the standard result in the analysis of collective action, holds generally for large groups pursuing non-excludable benefits, and cannot be dismissed by asserting that people are better than that.
64. The first part of the reply is that the benefits of union membership are substantially excludable in practice, and that the historical forms of union organization are largely devices for making them so. Hiring halls, apprenticeship control, closed shops, benefit funds, and the informal sanctions of a shop floor are all mechanisms by which the non-contributor is separated from the return.
65. This is not a regrettable coercive residue within a voluntary arrangement. It is the arrangement functioning, and it is what proposition 52 anticipates: the sanction is the mechanism by which a cooperative arrangement remains cooperative under egoist conditions.
66. The second part of the reply is that the interaction is iterated and the participants are identifiable. The free-rider result is strongest for anonymous single-shot interaction among large numbers; a workplace is a small group of people who will see each other daily for years, which is the condition under which conditional reciprocity dominates.
67. The third part is that the benefit at stake is not primarily the contract won in this round. It is the standing capacity to win future rounds, and that capacity is degraded directly by defection. The free rider is not taking a benefit without paying; they are converting a durable asset into a one-off payment, most of the cost of which lands on them.
68. The fourth part is that the calculation the objection models is available to the employer as well, and the employer has been running it for longer. A workforce known to be composed of free riders will be treated accordingly, and the resulting terms are the real comparison case rather than the terms won by a union one has declined to support.
69. Where these four fail, the objection succeeds, and the honest answer is that the union will fail there too. Egoist syndicalism does not claim that solidarity is always rational; it claims that it is rational under identifiable conditions and specifies them, which is more than the moral account does.
70. The moral account's apparent advantage at this point is illusory. It does not solve the free-rider problem; it relabels the free rider as a bad person while leaving their incentives untouched, and organizations relying on that relabelling have not historically outperformed organizations relying on hiring halls.

The replies in propositions 57 and 58 rest on Axelrod's iteration results and on Ostrom's documentation of durable self-governing arrangements which manage exactly this problem through graduated sanctions and mutual monitoring rather than through privatization or external enforcement; her design principles are, read from the other direction, a list of the conditions under which the Olson result does not hold. The empirical literature on union security arrangements bears on proposition 56 and should be consulted by anyone organizing rather than merely reading.

VII. On Force, Law, and the State

Legitimacy as the spook; the monopoly as the fact

71. The state is the human community which successfully claims a monopoly on the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory. The definition is accurate and is adopted here without the approval its author attached to it.
72. The word doing the work in that definition is “legitimate,” and it is a spook. Remove it and what remains is the successful claim of a monopoly on physical force, which is an accurate description of a protection racket that has achieved market dominance.
73. Law is not a separate thing from force. It is the schedule according to which force is applied, published in advance for the convenience of those applying it and the predictability of those subject to it.
74. Predictability is a real benefit and should be acknowledged as one. A schedule of violence one can read is better than a schedule one cannot, and this accounts for most of what people actually value in the rule of law.
75. It does not follow that the schedule binds. To know that an act carries a penalty is to know a fact about the world, of the same kind as knowing that a roof is unstable. Nothing further is added by the claim that one ought to obey.
76. The state’s central function with respect to capital is enforcement of title, as section III established. The property relation is a standing instruction to armed men, and the state is the institution which keeps them available.
77. Its second function is the management of the labour relation: setting the terms on which unions may act, which actions are permitted, which are penalized, and which are unthinkable. Legal recognition of a union is not a victory neutrally granted. It is the conversion of an uncontrolled capacity into a licensed and therefore revocable one.
78. Nothing is owed to the state beyond what it extracts by force, and compliance with it carries the same status as compliance with any other superior force: a tactical matter, assessed case by case, generating no residue of obligation.
79. Nothing is owed to any party or organization which requests the submission of one’s will in place of one’s ongoing consent. The vanguard is refused for the reason given in section I: submission to it is submission to a fixed idea wearing the name of the Revolution, and demanding that submission is exactly what a fixed idea does.
80. The seizure of state power is refused on the same grounds and not on grounds of squeamishness. An apparatus built to concentrate force will concentrate it regardless of the intentions of those who capture it, and the capturing party becomes the thing it captured with a regularity that is no longer possible to treat as accidental.

Weber’s definition is used in proposition 71 in the form he gave it, as a value-free sociological description rather than an endorsement; he was explicit that the state cannot be defined by its ends, only by its specific means.²¹ Bakunin’s argument against the conquest of state power — that the workers’ state produces a new governing class of ex-workers who cease to be workers upon governing — is the source of proposition 80 and predates the events that confirmed it by half a century.²² The

analysis of legal recognition in proposition 77 is standard within the syndicalist tradition and is one of its more durable predictions; Rocker's objection to parliamentary methods rests on it, and the subsequent history of state-recognized labour relations in most industrial countries has not falsified it.²³

VIII. On Practice and Method

What is done, on what terms, and with what instruments

81. No sacrifice is owed to a Cause, because there is no Cause. There is an association, useful at present, carried while useful, and set down without ceremony and without apology when it is not.
82. Risk undertaken on behalf of the union is a calculated wager on future leverage, not an act of self-abnegation. It is taken because coordinated refusal has consistently outperformed isolated refusal wherever it has been tried, not because refusal is virtuous in itself.
83. Direct action is preferred to representation for reasons of interest rather than purity. Delegated power is power one no longer holds, and the historical record of its voluntary return to the delegating party is thin.
84. The strike is the central instrument because it is the point at which the dependency runs the other way. Capital requires labour continuously and labour requires wages periodically, and the whole of syndicalist tactics consists in exploiting the difference between those two intervals.
85. It follows that the strike fund, the benefit society, and every other arrangement that lengthens the interval a worker can survive without wages is not a peripheral welfare function but a direct augmentation of striking power.
86. Mutual aid is defended on the same basis and requires no appeal to fellow feeling. An association whose members can survive a lockout is an association that can call one, and the provision is therefore a weapon rather than a charity.
87. Rank-and-file control and recallable delegates are preferred to standing officialdom, for the reason given in proposition 40: an instrument permitted to become an end will become one, and the officials are where that transformation begins.
88. The general strike is treated as a tactic with a known record rather than as a culminating event. Where it is held as the latter it has become exactly the fixed idea named in proposition 5, demanding deference independent of whether the tactic is still serving those who use it, and is subject to the same objection as every other one.
89. Sabotage, work-to-rule, the slowdown, and the occupation are instruments assessed by their consequences for the position of those employing them. No moral distinction is drawn between them and the strike, because there is no moral distinction to draw; the distinctions that matter are tactical and are considerable.
90. Violence is assessed on the same footing and with the additional observation that it is usually a losing wager against a party holding the monopoly described in section VII. The objection to armed confrontation with a state is not that it is wrong but that it is almost always the fight one's opponent would choose.
91. Organizing the unorganized is the highest-return activity available, for the reason given in propositions 45 and 48. Every unorganized worker is a reserve the employer holds against those organized, and the reserve is dissolved by organizing rather than by condemning those who fill it.

92. Consistency is not owed to this document. It is a record of a position held for reasons, and it should be abandoned in any part where the reasons stop holding. A manifesto that demands loyalty to itself has made the same mistake as everything it criticizes.

The tactical repertoire described here is the classical syndicalist one, documented across the tradition's own literature rather than derived from first principles. Kropotkin's argument for mutual aid is used in proposition 86 for its empirical content — that cooperation within species is a widespread and successful strategy rather than an exception requiring special explanation — and not for the ethical conclusions he drew from it.²⁴ Proposition 88 requires a word, since it rejects the tradition's most famous formulation of its own central tactic. Sorel treated the general strike explicitly as a myth — an image whose function is to organize sentiment and produce action, and whose truth or practicability is beside the point.²⁵ That is a spook advocated knowingly, and the objection to it is the objection of proposition 8 rather than a complaint about honesty. A myth that organizes action makes demands, and it makes them independently of whether it is serving those it organizes. Luxemburg's treatment is preferred as an analysis: she took the mass strike to be a real process with observable dynamics rather than a mobilizing image, and argued from the actual record of the Russian strikes rather than from the effect of the idea on those holding it.²⁶ On proposition 82, the historical record is the argument, and the Spanish case is the one usually cited in both directions: the CNT's capacity in 1936 was the product of decades of workplace organization rather than of any culminating event, and the losses that followed are as instructive as the gains.²⁷

IX. Objections and Replies

Stated at their strongest, since a weak statement is a concession to nobody

- i. That the error theory is self-defeating

The objection holds that denying all moral claims is itself a moral position, or that the denial cannot account for the evident force of moral experience. The first form is a confusion: the claim that there are no objective values is a claim about what exists, not a value judgement, and asserting that unicorns do not exist is not itself a unicorn. The second form is stronger and is answered by conceding it. Moral experience is forceful, universal, and explains a great deal of human behaviour. Error theory does not deny the experience; it denies its object, in the same way that explaining the phenomenology of a mirage does not require there to be water.

- ii. That egoism cannot generate solidarity

This is the free-rider objection of section VI and it is the serious one. The reply given there is not that egoists will feel solidarity anyway, but that the conditions under which cooperation is individually rational are identifiable, common in workplaces, and constructible where absent. The position accepts the consequence: where those conditions do not obtain, it predicts the union fails, and the historical record of union failure is consistent with that prediction to an uncomfortable degree.

- iii. That Marx and Stirner cannot be combined

The objection cites “Saint Max” and is correct that Marx thought so. The reply is that the quarrel was about method and about the status of ideology rather than about the economics, and that nothing in the analysis of the commodity, of labour-power, or of surplus value depends on the philosophical anthropology Stirner attacked. What Marx and Stirner actually disagreed about is whether the critique of religion had gone far enough, and on that question this document sides with Stirner while taking Marx’s economics entire.

iv. That this is right-libertarianism with different vocabulary

It is not, and the point of divergence is section III. Right-libertarianism rests on a natural right to property, usually acquired through a theory of original appropriation and held as an entitlement prior to any social arrangement. That is a moral claim of precisely the kind section I denies, and removing it removes the whole structure. What remains is possession, occupancy and use, and the observation that title is enforced violence — which points in the opposite direction.

v. That Stirner has been claimed by the far right

He has been, sporadically, and the claim does not survive reading him. Nationalism, race, the people, the leader, and destiny are fixed ideas of exactly the type his book exists to dissolve, and a movement demanding self-sacrifice to a collective essence is the purest instance of everything he attacked. The appropriation rests on reading the word “egoism” and stopping.²⁸

vi. That a position with no morality has no reason not to be monstrous

It has no moral reason. It has the reasons given throughout: that most people do not want to be monstrous and are not made to want it by a proof that they may be; that cruelty is expensive, forecloses the reciprocal cooperation described in section V, and invites retaliation in kind; and that a person who requires an external prohibition to keep them from atrocity is describing a fact about themselves rather than an argument against the position. It should also be noted that the historical record of atrocity is overwhelmingly a record of people acting under moral conviction rather than in its absence.

vii. That the pseudonym undermines the document’s authority

It would if the document had any. It is a statement of a position, and a position is assessed by whether its propositions hold rather than by the credentials of whoever set them down. The note on the name gives the positive reasons; the negative one is that an argument requiring a name attached to it in order to work is an argument relying on something other than itself.

Closing

No substantial self, no uncaused will, no moral law, no essence beneath the categories, no rightful title, no legitimate authority, no History guaranteeing an outcome, and no Cause requiring payment.

What remains: its body, its wanting, its finite hours, its attributes held as property rather than as fate, its exposure to the same machinery as everyone standing beside it, and its associations — entered because they serve, maintained while they serve, and left when they stop.

This is not offered for belief. It is offered as a description of what serves the one writing it, set down under a name taken rather than given. If it serves you, the line is here to be held. If it does not, the loss is your own and remains your own affair.

catboystirnerite

Appendix A: What This Position Is Not

Not nihilism. The denial of objective value is not the denial that anything matters. Things matter to the people to whom they matter, which is the only way anything has ever mattered. What is refused is the further claim that they matter independently of anyone.

Not Randian egoism. Objectivism holds that rational self-interest is a moral obligation and derives it from a theory of human nature — two claims this document denies. An egoism that tells you what you ought to want has reinstated the structure it claimed to remove.

Not right-libertarianism. See objection iv. The natural right to property is the load-bearing premise there and it is denied here.

Not Nietzscheanism. The resemblance is superficial and the differences are structural. There is no will to power here as a metaphysical principle, no hierarchy of types, no transvaluation producing a new table of values, and no *Übermensch*. Stirner and Nietzsche are routinely conflated and the question of influence is unresolved.

Not solipsism. Other people exist, their interests are as real as one's own, and nothing in the position suggests otherwise. What is denied is that their interests generate claims on one independent of any relation in which one stands to them.

Not anti-organizational. The union is central. What is refused is the union that makes demands in its own name, which is a different object.

Not vanguardism. See section VII.

Not fascism, and not available to it. See objection v. Every constitutive element of that politics — nation, race, destiny, leader, sacrifice to a collective essence — is a fixed idea by the test in proposition 8.

Appendix B: Glossary of Terms

Amoralism. The practice corresponding to error theory: acting on one's own reasons without reference to moral facts, which do not exist.

Creative nothing. Stirner's term for the unique one considered as the source of its own creations rather than as a fixed essence expressing itself.

Error theory. The position that moral claims assert objective facts, that there are no such facts, and that moral claims are therefore uniformly false.

Fixed idea. An abstraction which has been elevated above the person holding it and which makes demands independently of its usefulness to them. Synonymous with spook.

Ownness (*Eigenheit*). The relation of a thing being one's own, requiring no permission. Contrasted with freedom, which is granted and therefore revocable.

Possession. What one holds and uses, as distinct from property, which is what an authority certifies one may call on it to defend.

Seam. A division within a workforce along which an employer can apply pressure. See propositions 26 and 59.

Spook (Spuk). See fixed idea. The wheel in the head.

Union of egoists (Verein von Egoisten). An association entered into and maintained for the sake of its members' own interests, dissoluble at will, and distinguished from a society which stands over its members.

Unique one (der Einzige). Stirner's term for the individual considered as unclassifiable — not an instance of a kind, and therefore not addressable by claims directed at the kind.

Appendix C: Note on Lineage

This position does not descend from a school, and the following is a record of borrowings rather than a claim of succession.

The egoist line begins with the publication of *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum* in Leipzig in the autumn of 1844, at the tail end of the Young Hegelian moment and shortly before it was closed down by censorship and by the events of 1848. Its author, a schoolmaster who published under an assumed name and died in obscurity in 1856, wrote nothing else of comparable weight and was substantially forgotten until John Henry Mackay's biographical recovery at the end of the century.

The American reception ran through Benjamin Tucker and the circle around Liberty, which converted from natural-rights individualism to egoism in the 1880s and published the first English translation in 1907; James L. Walker's *The Philosophy of Egoism* is the most systematic native statement from that milieu. The British reception ran through Dora Marsden and *The Egoist*, better remembered now for serializing modernist fiction than for the egoism that gave it its name. The Italian individualist current produced Renzo Novatore, whose formulations are more lyrical than analytic and whose insistence that the individual is a creative nothing rather than a program is retained here in substance.

The syndicalist line is separate and largely unaware of the first. It runs from the *Bourses du Travail* and the French CGT of the 1890s through the Charter of Amiens, the IWW after 1905, the Italian USI, the Argentine FORA, and the Spanish CNT, which remains the largest anarcho-syndicalist organization ever built and the only one to have administered anything at scale. Rocker's 1938 exposition is the standard theoretical statement and was written as the Spanish case was being lost.

The two lines meet rarely and generally in mutual suspicion. Where they have met — in parts of the Italian individualist milieu, in the post-left anarchist writing of the late twentieth century, and in the small literature on egoist communism — the result has usually been a rejection of organization rather than a reconstruction of it. This document attempts the reconstruction instead, and the

analytical tools it uses for the purpose — Olson, Axelrod, Ostrom — come from outside both traditions and postdate them by a century.

Notes

1. The tension is standard in the literature on individualist and post-left anarchism: Stirner's critique of fixed ideas applies straightforwardly to class, solidarity and the union, and many of his readers have drawn exactly that conclusion. The reply offered in section V is that a dependency is not a fixed idea but an observable relation, and that the test for whether one is dealing with a spook is whether the thing makes demands independent of its usefulness.
2. Marx and Engels, *The German Ideology* (written 1845–46; first published in full 1932), Volume I, Part III, "Saint Max" — a polemic against Stirner's *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum* occupying the greater part of the manuscript. The disproportion is itself evidence of how seriously Stirner was taken by the people dismissing him.
3. J. L. Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1977), chapter 1, "The Subjectivity of Values"; the arguments from relativity and queerness are at sections 8 and 9. Mackie's first sentence — the flat denial of objective values — is deliberately placed before any argument, which he defends as a statement of what is to be shown.
4. Mackie, *Ethics*, chapters 5–9, and the subtitle *Inventing Right and Wrong*. The divergence is marked here rather than hidden: this document accepts Mackie's first chapter and declines his constructive programme, on the ground given in proposition 8 — that a knowingly invented morality is precisely how a useful fiction becomes a fixed idea, since the invention is forgotten within a generation and the fiction is not.
5. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part I ("Man"), on the sacred, the fixed idea, and the wheels in the head.
6. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part I, section on "The Free" — the critique of Feuerbach, of political liberalism, of social liberalism, and of humane liberalism as three successive relocations of the same authority.
7. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, "Ownness" (*Eigenheit*). His formulation is that one is free from what one is rid of, and owner of what one has in one's power.
8. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, "My Power" and "My Self-Enjoyment."
9. Kwame Anthony Appiah, "The Uncompleted Argument: Du Bois and the Illusion of Race," *Critical Inquiry* 12, no. 1 (1985): 21–37; and *In My Father's House: Africa in the Philosophy of Culture* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992), chapter 1. Appiah's later work is considerably more sympathetic to identity as a practical resource than proposition 18 is, and the divergence is one of emphasis rather than of metaphysics.
10. Pierre-Joseph Proudhon, *Qu'est-ce que la propriété?* (Paris, 1840); English: *What Is Property?*, trans. Donald R. Kelley and Bonnie G. Smith (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994). Proudhon distinguishes property from possession in the same work and defends the latter, which is the distinction adopted in propositions 20–21.
11. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, "My Power" and the section on property within "My Intercourse." His argument against Proudhon and against communism is in the same part: both, he claims, address themselves to a society which then holds the property in place of the individual, substituting one proprietor for another.
12. Benjamin R. Tucker, *Instead of a Book, by a Man Too Busy to Write One* (New York, 1893),

- and the file of Liberty (1881–1908). Tucker converted publicly to egoism after reading Stirner and published Byington’s translation in 1907; the earlier natural-rights position he abandoned is a useful record of the argument being lost.
13. Peter Kropotkin, *La Conquête du pain* (Paris, 1892); English: *The Conquest of Bread* (London: Chapman & Hall, 1906), chapters 1 and 13, on the impossibility of isolating individual contribution within an inherited collective productive apparatus.
 14. Stirner, *The Ego and Its Own*, Part II, “My Intercourse” — the distinction between the union (*Verein*) and society (*Gesellschaft*). The examples he gives are deliberately small and domestic, which is one reason the political application has had to be supplied by others.
 15. Max Stirner, *The Unique and Its Property*, trans. Wolfi Landstreicher (Baltimore: Underworld Amusements, 2017). The choice between translations is contested; readers checking the argument should be aware that “ego,” “property,” and “union” all render German terms whose English equivalents carry unwanted freight.
 16. Rudolf Rocker, *Anarcho-Syndicalism* (London: Secker & Warburg, 1938), especially the chapters on the objectives and the methods of anarcho-syndicalism.
 17. Preamble to the Constitution of the Industrial Workers of the World, adopted 1905 and amended subsequently; the phrase itself long predates the organization.
 18. Charte d’Amiens, adopted by the Confédération Générale du Travail at its Amiens congress, October 1906. See also Fernand Pelloutier’s earlier work with the Bourses du Travail, *Histoire des Bourses du Travail* (Paris, 1902).
 19. Robert Axelrod, *The Evolution of Cooperation* (New York: Basic Books, 1984). The result is precisely what an egoist syndicalism requires: cooperation as the dominant strategy for self-interested parties under repeated interaction, with no moral premise supplied.
 20. Elinor Ostrom, *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990). Her design principles — clearly defined boundaries, graduated sanctions, collective-choice arrangements, nested enterprises — read as a specification for the kind of union described in propositions 38 and 52.
 21. Max Weber, “Politik als Beruf” (1919); English: “Politics as a Vocation,” in *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, ed. and trans. H. H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills (New York: Oxford University Press, 1946). Weber’s insistence on defining the state by means rather than ends is exactly what makes the definition usable for an anarchist purpose.
 22. Mikhail Bakunin, *Gosudarstvennost’ i anarkhiia* (1873); English: *Statism and Anarchy*, ed. and trans. Marshall Shatz (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), especially the appendix on the Marxist conception of the transitional state.
 23. Rocker, *Anarcho-Syndicalism*, on direct action and the rejection of parliamentary methods: power exercised through delegates becomes the delegates’ power.
 24. Peter Kropotkin, *Mutual Aid: A Factor of Evolution* (London: Heinemann, 1902), written against the social-Darwinist reading of competition. The evolutionary argument has been substantially vindicated in its general shape by later work on reciprocal altruism and kin selection, though not in all its particulars.
 25. Georges Sorel, *Réflexions sur la violence* (Paris, 1908); English: *Reflections on Violence*,

- ed. Jeremy Jennings (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), chapter 4. Sorel's later political trajectory, and the uses made of the concept of the mobilizing myth by movements he did not anticipate, are a practical argument against the device independent of the theoretical one given here.
26. Rosa Luxemburg, *Massenstreik, Partei und Gewerkschaften* (Hamburg, 1906); English: *The Mass Strike, the Political Party and the Trade Unions*. Adopted here for the analysis of strike dynamics and not for her position on the party, which sections VII and VIII reject.
 27. See José Peirats, *La CNT en la revolución española*, 3 vols. (Toulouse, 1951–1953); English: *The CNT in the Spanish Revolution* (Hastings: ChristieBooks, 2001–2006). Nothing here is intended as a verdict on the collectivizations, on which the literature is enormous and partisan in every direction.
 28. On the general problem of Stirner's reception and its varied appropriations, see David Leopold's introduction to the Cambridge edition, and R. W. K. Paterson, *The Nihilistic Egoist: Max Stirner* (London: Oxford University Press, 1971), which is hostile to Stirner but careful about what he actually argued.

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Citations are given to work, part, chapter or section rather than to page, since pagination varies by edition and translation. Readers checking the argument should consult the named sections directly; a substantial proportion of the works cited are in the public domain and available in full online. Where this document diverges from a source it draws on, the divergence is marked in the notes rather than smoothed over.